

says B.L. Tiwari, the VHP's key liaison with the sadhus and seers in Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh.

Of the 64 recommendations sent by the board, none has been accepted so far. These include a new law as well as amendments to 11 existing laws that concern bodies like trusts and cooperatives to streamline the functioning of temples and mutts. After being ignored for over two years, the board passed a resolution in February, condemning the Government's apathy towards its proposals. The strength of the 65-member body has come down to 38 as many stopped attending its quarterly meetings as they thought the Government had set up the board in 2007 to bide time, not resolve issues.

Some of the key demands include a complete ban on ad hoc auction of temple lands for cultivation by the government to realise land revenue. The Government is in charge of the properties, upkeep and finances of a category labelled as government-run and government-maintained temples and mutts. The temporal matters of these 14,000 temples in the state with about 1.5 lakh acres of land were passed on to the Government via district collectors on account of large-scale complaints against mismanagement of finances of the temples' earnings through properties and donations.

**SEERS
WANT AN
UMBRELLA
LAW FOR
MANAGE-
MENT OF
TEMPLES**



Over a lakh sadhus are demanding that the Government's **CONTROL OVER 14,000** temples and 1.5 lakh acres of land be lifted.

When the BJP came to power in 2003 in state, priests and seers hoped that the party would heed their demands. The Chouhan Government set out to resolve the demands through a Sant-Pujari-Mahant Sammelan in Bhopal in December 2006 and managed to defuse the situation. In April 2007, the demands were raised again, prompting the Government to announce constitution of the advisory board. "The Government is not in a mood to introduce the law. It wants to retain control of vast temple properties

even as thousands of priests survive on a pittance," says Tiwari.

Over the last few decades the state Government has taken over some of the most important religious seats like Maihar in Satna and Mahakaal in Ujjain with huge incomes. The Government-run and maintained temples mostly date back to the British period when they were patronised by local royalty. After Independence, they were passed on to the Government and are handled by the Religious Trusts and Endowment Department, which pays up to Rs 500 monthly honorarium for priests. A proposal in the offing is to cross-subsidise the poorer temples with rich ones since there is a limit to which the Government can plough public money into temples. However, members of the advisory board allege that the Government takes more than it gives back to the temples and mutts. "We represent 1.10 lakh priests. The Government has done nothing to improve the lot of priests. They cannot ignore our demands," claims Narendra Dixit, president of the Madhya Pradesh Pujari Mahasangh.

This time around, the Government's own advisory board members are striking a discordant note because they feel short-changed. While the seers may be split along political lines, temporal affairs of temples and mutts will continue to toll warning bells. ■

UNHOLY DIVIDE

THE BUILDUP

- Mid-'90s: Government starts auction of temple lands to recover dues
- 2001-02: VHP scuttles plan to introduce a law regulating temples
- 2006: Chouhan defuses demands at Sant-Pujari-Mahant Sammelan
- 2008: President of Madhya Pradesh Pujari Mahasangh holds fast-unto-death; Advisory Board sends draft umbrella Bill to government
- 2010: Advisory board passes resolution condemning government apathy towards the sadhus' demands

WHAT SADHUS WANT

- Complete ban on auction of land belonging to 1,400 temples and mutts across the state
- Passage of model Act for management of temples and properties
- Amendments to 11 existing laws to streamline temple management
- Increased honorarium for priests in government-managed temples from Rs 500 per month to Rs 5,000
- A total of 64 recommendations sent to the Government, not a single one accepted